THE REAL COST OF *Fascism* IN AMERICA

SUMMARY OF FINDINGS FROM THE RECORD THE CEA LEFT OUT:
THE ECONOMIC AND CONSTITUTIONAL COST OF DONALD TRUMP,
2017 TO 2021 AND 2025 TO PRESENT

The Council of Economic Advisers recently priced out a socialist agenda that has not been enacted. This summary prices out the record of a president who has held office twice. Across both terms that record includes two trade wars, two deficit-financed tax laws, a war Congress never authorized, money Congress appropriated and the White House refused to spend, an attempt to fire a Federal Reserve governor, troops deployed to American cities, children separated from their parents at the border, and prosecutions of the president's critics. Every figure below comes from a federal agency, a federal court, or a nonpartisan budget model. Where those bodies found the conduct unlawful, we say so in their words.

COUNCIL OF ECONOMIC RECEIPTS

NOT THE WHITE HOUSE

A counter to White House propaganda. Not affiliated with or endorsed by the Executive Office of the President or the Council of Economic Advisers. The joke's on us; the numbers are the government's.

$34,000

Added federal deficit per household from the 2025 tax law, using the same division CEA used to get its $355,000 figure[8]

−$2,600 / +$8,200

Average yearly income change over the coming decade for the poorest tenth of households versus the richest tenth, from the tax law and tariffs combined[9]

$45.1 billion

($45,100,000,000)

Cost of the Iran war through September 2026, as the Pentagon reported to Congress. Congress never authorized the war.[17]

THE BOTTOM LINE

The CEA scored a $49 trillion agenda that exists on paper. The agenda actually in force has a receipt, and it covers two terms. The first term added about $7.8 trillion **($7,800,000,000,000)** to the national debt and opened a trade war that taxpayers then paid farmers $23 billion **($23,000,000,000)** to survive. The second term imposed tariffs the Supreme Court held were never legal, signed a tax law that adds $4.7 trillion **($4,700,000,000,000)** to deficits, and launched a war that has cost the Pentagon $45.1 billion and drivers another $123.4 billion **($123,351,580,606)** at the pump. Across both terms, courts and the GAO have repeatedly found the executive branch acting outside the law. CEA scored none of it.

IF FINANCED BY IMPORT TAXES:

- Tariffs are a tax paid at the border and passed through at the register. In February 2026 the Supreme Court held that the power to impose them belongs to Congress, and that the emergency tariffs were unlawful.[1] More than $100 billion **($100,000,000,000)** has been refunded to importers. No mechanism returns the higher prices consumers paid.[2]
- The tariffs still in force cost the average household about $1,100 a year, roughly $1.9 trillion **($1,900,000,000,000)** over ten years.[3] CBO finds they raise goods prices more than services, which falls hardest on lower-income households.[5]
- First term: New York Fed economists estimated that one round of China tariffs, raised to 25 percent in 2019, cost the typical household $831 a year.[21] Retaliation hit farmers, and USDA paid them $23 billion in trade aid for 2018 and 2019.[22]

IF FINANCED BY BORROWING:

- CBO's score of the 2025 tax law: $4.7 trillion **($4,700,000,000,000)** added to deficits through 2035, including $0.9 trillion **($900,000,000,000)** in extra interest. CBO projects a $1.9 trillion **($1,900,000,000,000)** deficit in fiscal 2026, rising to $3.1 trillion **($3,100,000,000,000)** by 2036.[6]
- First term: CBO estimated the 2017 tax law adds about $1.9 trillion **($1,900,000,000,000)** to deficits over 2018 to 2028, after counting economic feedback and interest.[23]
- The national debt rose from $19.95 trillion to $27.75 trillion during the first term. About $3.25 trillion **($3,250,000,000,000)** of that came before the pandemic; most of the rest came during it, including more than $3 trillion in COVID relief that Congress passed.[24]

IF FINANCED BY WAR:

- CBO counts $38.1 billion **($38,100,000,000)** in Pentagon combat costs through August 1, 2026, and $2 billion to $3 billion more each month if operations continue. The Pentagon's own figure through September is $45.1 billion.[16,17] The itemized bill follows on the next page.

THE IRAN WAR, ITEMIZED

The United States and Israel struck Iran on February 28, 2026. The President never sought authorization from Congress. Below is CBO's breakdown of what the Pentagon spent through August 1, 2026.[16,18]

Munitions to replace Missiles and bombs fired, which must be rebuilt	**$21.7 billion** **($21,700,000,000)**
Interceptor missiles	**$13.1 billion** **($13,100,000,000)**
Land-strike cruise missiles	**$7.3 billion** **($7,300,000,000)**
Other munitions	**$1.2 billion** **($1,200,000,000)**
Additional flight operations	**$10.4 billion** **($10,400,000,000)**
Extra fuel	**$2.7 billion** **($2,700,000,000)**
Combat equipment lost	**$1.9 billion** **($1,900,000,000)**
Other operations	**$1.5 billion** **($1,500,000,000)**
TOTAL, THROUGH AUG. 1	**$38.1 billion** **($38,100,000,000)**
Each additional month CBO: about $2 billion at May–June intensity, $3 billion at July intensity	**$2–3 billion**

Bars are drawn to scale against the largest item. Line items are rounded by CBO and sum to $38.2 billion. CBO's estimate excludes damage to bases, casualty costs, and future veterans' health care and disability, and CBO says the U.S. has probably used one-half to two-thirds of its stock of certain interceptors, which will take at least five years to rebuild.[16]

PAID AT THE PUMP

$922

Average extra gasoline and diesel cost per household from February 28 to October 26, 2026; $123,351,580,606 nationwide. ITEP's estimate from EIA weekly fuel data; it excludes jet fuel and heating oil.[19]

Energy prices were up 20.4 percent over the year to September 2026.[7]

PAID IN LIVES

18 killed

U.S. service members killed, by the Pentagon's count as of July 2026, with about 482 wounded in its casualty database at that time.[18]

Fighting resumed in July after an April ceasefire. In June both chambers passed a War Powers resolution directing an end to U.S. involvement; as a concurrent resolution it is not binding.[14]

THE DEBT, TERM BY TERM

Gross federal debt at the start of each presidency and today. He calls himself the "king of debt." The Treasury agrees.[20,24,33]

January 2017 Trump's first inauguration	**$19.95 trillion** **($19,950,000,000,000)**
January 2021 Trump leaves office: +$7.8 trillion in four years	**$27.75 trillion** **($27,750,000,000,000)**
January 2025 Trump's second inauguration: +$8.45 trillion under Biden, split below	**$36.2 trillion** **($36,200,000,000,000)**
SEPTEMBER 30, 2026 +$4.0 trillion in his first 20 months back	**$40.17 trillion** **($40,171,825,101,340)**

Bars are drawn to scale against the September 2026 total. Gross federal debt, including debt held by federal trust funds.

SPLITTING THE BIDEN-ERA DEBT

The debt rose $8.45 trillion between Biden's inauguration and Trump's return. Part of that bill was Trump's: interest on the debt he ran up, his tax law's revenue loss, and relief he signed that paid out after he left. Here is the math, step by step.

Biden-era increase

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Debt Jan. 17, 2025 − Debt Jan. 19, 2021
$36,206,593,315,575 − $27,752,835,868,445
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= $8,453,757,447,130

A. Interest on Trump's first-term debt, FY2021–2024

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Σ (net interest that year × $7.808 trillion Trump added ÷ total debt that year)
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Fiscal year	Net interest	Total debt, year end	Trump's share	Interest on his debt
2021	$352B	$28.43T	27.5%	$96.7B
2022	$475B	$30.93T	25.2%	$119.9B
2023	$659B	$33.17T	23.5%	$155.1B
2024	$870B	$35.46T	22.0%	$191.6B

= $563.3 billion ($563,300,000,000)

B. 2017 tax law revenue loss, FY2021–2024

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$220.8B + $178.3B + $137.9B + $120.1B (Joint Committee on Taxation)
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= $657.1 billion ($657,100,000,000)

C. December 2020 relief law Trump signed

`Signed Dec. 27, 2020; ten-year cost per CRFB, paid out mostly after he left`

= $915 billion ($915,000,000,000)

Documented Trump carryover

`A + B + C = $563.3B + $657.1B + $915B`

= $2.14 trillion ($2,135,400,000,000)

Debt Biden added on his own

`$8,453.8B − $2,135.4B`

= $6.32 trillion ($6,318,400,000,000)

Our argument: D. The 2021 relief law, charged to the pandemic Trump mishandled

`CBO ten-year score of the American Rescue Plan Act; reasoning below`

= $1.9 trillion ($1,900,000,000,000)

Carryover including D

`$2,135.4B + $1,900B`

= $4.04 trillion ($4,035,400,000,000)

Debt Biden added on his own, including D

`$8,453.8B − $4,035.4B`

= $4.42 trillion ($4,418,400,000,000)

First term

`Debt Jan. 19, 2021 − Debt Jan. 19, 2017 = $27,752,835,868,445 − $19,944,429,217,107`

= $7.81 trillion ($7,808,406,651,338)

Second term, so far

`Debt Sept. 30, 2026 − Debt Jan. 17, 2025 = $40,171,825,101,340 − $36,206,593,315,575`

= $3.97 trillion ($3,965,231,785,765)

His bill during Biden's term, including D

`A + B + C + D, from above`

= $4.04 trillion ($4,035,400,000,000)

Total debt attributable to Trump

`$7,808.4B + $3,965.2B + $4,035.4B`

= $15.81 trillion ($15,809,000,000,000)

`39 percent of the $40.17 trillion national debt. Without line D: $13.91 trillion ($13,909,000,000,000), 35 percent.`

Lines A through C are documented costs; line D is our argument, shown separately so readers can take it or leave it. Line A is our calculation from CRFB interest figures and Treasury debt totals; FY2024 interest is CBO's projection as reported by CRFB. Line A

counts interest on all debt added on Trump's watch, including bipartisan COVID relief. Fiscal 2021 began in October 2020, so about four months of it were Trump's. Line B is a 2017 static estimate and excludes interest on the new borrowing. Lines C and D are ten-year scores; some of C was paid before January 20, 2021, and small parts of both were paid after 2024, so those lines slightly overstate the Biden-era share. The 2021 law also funded items beyond pandemic response, such as the expanded child tax credit and multiemployer pension relief. The first- and second-term lines count all debt added on Trump's watch, including interest on debt from earlier administrations; we did not apply to those terms the carryover deductions we applied to Biden's. The second-term line starts January 17, 2025, three days before his inauguration, the nearest Treasury figure we have.[20,38–43]

WHY WE CHARGE THE 2021 RELIEF LAW TO TRUMP

- **The pandemic he mishandled kept billing.** The Lancet Commission on Public Policy and Health found that if U.S. COVID death rates had matched the average of the other G7 nations, 40 percent of American COVID deaths could have been averted. The commission tied that to his administration's response and to longer-running public health failures.[34] Instead of tougher precautions, he promoted hydroxychloroquine; the FDA revoked its emergency authorization in June 2020 after finding it "has not demonstrated effectiveness in treating or preventing COVID-19."[35] At a White House briefing in April 2020 he asked whether disinfectant could be used "by injection inside or almost a cleaning," and the maker of Lysol had to warn that its products should never go into the body "under any circumstance."[44] A longer, deadlier pandemic required more relief, including the $1.9 trillion relief law of 2021.

BRIBES, PAID FOR BY YOU

He has stamped 1776, the year of the Declaration of Independence, on a payout twice. The first time, he lied about where the money came from. The second time, it dressed up a settlement of his own lawsuit against his own government, and a federal judge threw the deal out as a sham.

- **$5,000 for your vote: the "Trump dividend."** Eight weeks before the midterms he told a Republican convention, "If the Republicans win, you win with us and you get $5,000." Checks to roughly 245 million adults would cost about $1.2 trillion **($1,200,000,000,000)**. The Tax Foundation says that would use almost all the revenue the new tariffs are projected to raise over a decade, revenue Americans pay at the register. Its verdict on the promise: "Not gonna happen."[47]
- **The "tariff dividend."** He has promoted $2,000 checks paid from tariff revenue. The Tax Foundation found the revenue would not cover them, and tariffs are paid by Americans to begin with.[36]
- **1776, the first time: the $1,776 "Warrior Dividend."** He told troops their checks came from tariffs. That was false. The Pentagon paid them from a housing supplement Congress had already approved in the 2025 tax law: about $2.6 billion **($2,600,000,000)** across 1.45 million service members, money they were already set to receive.[36]
- **1776, the second time: the $1,776,000,000 "anti-weaponization" fund.** The Justice Department set it up in May 2026 as the condition for the President dropping his own $10 billion lawsuit against the IRS, an agency in his own administration. A DOJ order the next day shielded him and his family from government inquiries, including tax audits. Critics, including Republican senators, warned January 6 rioters could apply. A federal judge froze the fund. His acting attorney general told Congress it was "not moving forward, period," though Trump never agreed to drop it. Thirty-five former federal judges, including the conservative J. Michael Luttig, called the deal "a fraud on the Court." On July 13, 2026, U.S. District Judge Kathleen Williams voided the settlement in a 56-page ruling, finding the suit was brought "for an improper purpose — to gain the imprimatur of judicial legitimacy" for a deal with no real basis, and that "the Lead Plaintiff and the Government are one." In her words, "there was never a case or controversy."[37,45,46]

SECOND TERM, 2025 TO PRESENT

POLICY ACTION	COST OR LEGAL STATUS	WHAT THE RECORD SHOWS
Emergency tariffs (IEEPA) *"Liberation Day" duties of 10 to 50 percent on nearly every trading partner*	$166 billion **($166,000,000,000)** collected unlawfully; struck down 6 to 3, Feb. 20, 2026	The Court held IEEPA "does not authorize the President to impose tariffs." The Court of International Trade ordered refunds on March 4. Customs has paid out more than $100 billion **($100,000,000,000)**, with interest, to importers. Consumers who paid higher prices are not in line for any of it.[1,2]
Replacement tariffs *Sections 122, 232 and 301, reimposed after the ruling*	$1,100 / household per year; about $1.9 trillion over ten years **($1,900,000,000,000)**	Yale Budget Lab's July 2026 current-law estimate. Each round of new levies (Canada in August, 60 trading partners before that) adds to the bill. Apparel prices are estimated 17 percent higher under the tariffs.[3,4]
Inflation *Promise: lower prices on day one*	3.7% CPI 12 months to Sept. 2026; energy +20.4%	BLS: prices rose 0.6 percent in September alone. Gasoline rose 9.1 percent in the month and accounted for over half the increase. CBO attributes 0.4 points a year of 2025 and 2026 inflation to tariffs.[5,7]
2025 tax law *The "One Big Beautiful Bill Act," signed July 2025*	+$4.7 trillion **($4,700,000,000,000)** deficits through 2035 (CBO)	CBO: $3.7 trillion **($3,700,000,000,000)** in higher primary deficits plus $0.9 trillion **($900,000,000,000)** in debt service. Federal Medicaid spending falls $911 billion **($911,000,000,000)**, or 14 percent, through 2034. CBO projects about 10 million more uninsured from the law alone; with the expired ACA tax credits, more than 14 million in 2034.[6,10,11]
Impoundment *Refusing to spend money Congress appropriated*	12 GAO findings of illegal impoundment	GAO found violations involving EV charger funds, library grants, NIH research grants, school energy grants and a nearly $1 billion **($1,000,000,000)** "pocket rescission." GAO says the conduct subverts "Congress's power of the purse." GAO findings are not self-enforcing.[12,13]
Federal Reserve *Attempted firing of Governor Lisa Cook*	Blocked 5 to 4 Supreme Court, June 2026	The President announced Cook's removal in August 2025 over mortgage allegations she denies. The Court let her stay pending the case and stressed "real process and real cause." The President said he would keep trying.[15]
Troops in U.S. cities *National Guard deployed to Los Angeles and Washington, D.C.*	Ruled unlawful twice in federal court	A federal judge ruled in September 2025 that the Los Angeles deployment violated the Posse Comitatus Act, which bars using the military for domestic law enforcement. In November 2025 another judge ruled the D.C. deployment illegal and enjoined it. Both rulings were appealed.[25,26]
Prosecuting critics *Indictments of James Comey and Letitia James*	Dismissed Nov. 24, 2025	A federal judge threw out both indictments after finding Lindsey Halligan, the interim U.S. attorney the administration installed to bring them, was unlawfully appointed.[27]

POLICY ACTION	COST OR LEGAL STATUS	WHAT THE RECORD SHOWS
January 6 pardons *Clemency on his first day back in office*	~1,500 pardoned Jan. 20, 2025	The pardons covered defendants charged in the attack on the Capitol, in which the Justice Department says more than 140 police officers were assaulted.[28]
War with Iran *Military operations since Feb. 28, 2026*	Not authorized by Congress; $45.1 billion so far **($45,100,000,000)**	The President never sought congressional approval. The House (215 to 208) and Senate (50 to 48) passed a War Powers resolution directing an end to U.S. involvement, completed June 23, 2026. As a concurrent resolution it is not binding. Fighting resumed in July after an April ceasefire. Itemized costs are on the previous page.[14,16,17]

FIRST TERM, 2017 TO 2021

China trade war *25 percent tariffs on $200 billion of Chinese goods*	$831 / household per year, one round (NY Fed, 2019)	New York Fed economists put the cost at $831 per household per year: about $211 in tariffs paid and $620 in losses from shifting to costlier suppliers.[21]
Farm bailout *Market Facilitation Program*	$23 billion **($23,000,000,000)** paid 2018 and 2019	USDA paid farmers $23 billion to offset retaliation against the trade war. GAO found the agency's accuracy review unreliable and that it dropped its 2019 compliance review.[22]
2017 tax law *Tax Cuts and Jobs Act*	+$1.9 trillion **($1,900,000,000,000)** deficits 2018 to 2028 (CBO)	CBO's estimate after counting economic feedback and about $600 billion **($600,000,000,000)** in added interest. The debt rose by about $3.25 trillion in the three years before the pandemic.[23,24]
Ukraine aid withheld *Military aid Congress appropriated, held in summer 2019*	$214 million **($214,000,000)** GAO: violated the law	GAO found OMB "violated the ICA when it withheld USAI funds from obligation for policy reasons," adding that "faithful execution of the law does not permit the President to substitute his own policy priorities." The hold was the basis of his first impeachment.[29]
Border wall funding *Pentagon money moved to the wall without Congress*	Ruled unlawful Ninth Circuit, June 26, 2020	The appeals court held the transfer was not authorized by the defense appropriations act and "violated the Appropriations Clause" of the Constitution.[30]
Family separation *"Zero tolerance" at the southern border*	3,913 children separated, July 2017 to Jan. 2021	The federal Family Reunification Task Force identified 3,913 children separated from their families under the policy.[31]
January 6 *Second impeachment, for incitement of insurrection*	57 to 43 to convict; 67 needed	A majority of the Senate, including seven Republicans, voted to convict on February 13, 2021. The vote fell short of the two-thirds the Constitution requires.[32]

Dollar figures are as published by each source and are not additive across rows. Legal findings are quoted or paraphrased from the court or agency decision. Superscripts refer to the sources below.

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